

Design complexity. The first and foremost parameter to consider is the kind of boards/products you want to design. If all the designs you expect to create are of less to medium complexity, you can go for relatively simpler, low-performance tools/suites like OrCAD, PADS or Proteus.

What your target customers use. It is necessary to understand the EDA products used by the service providers to whom you are delivering the design. If the customer uses one tool and you give them a design that cannot be compatible with that tool, you may lose the customer. Of course, there are other tools available online that can convert the output design file to a different format. But that requires more effort and time. So it is best to use the tools that are compatible with those used by your customers.

Product design. Some of the products put more emphasis on the electronics and electrical part; the physical form of the product is less important.

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Some other products have a prominent mechanical form and the electronics part is limited to a PCB and a couple of wires. Tools like Altium Designer and CR-8000 provide better integration or co-design of electronic CAD (ECAD) and mechanical CAD (MCAD) elements for designing the final product.

Cost. Price of the software tool(s) can be a constraint for start-ups, small and medium enterprises (SMEs) and academia. If the design complexity is less, one can always go for free and open source tools. Generally, paid-for tools offer more and better features besides the support required for complex designs. Tools like Allegro can be very expensive but price of CADSTAR is a bit on the lower side. The cost of Altium Designer is in between these two.

Some EDA firms offer flexible purchasing schemes. The customer can buy licence for only certain modules of the suite instead of buying the entire package. More tools from the package can be purchased later, when required. There is also a feature called floating licence which allows the use of the same licence on multiple machines so that the user does not have to buy separate licences for multiple systems. Almost all vendors provide the evaluation version of their software for usually one month.

Support from the vendors. Many of the EDA tool vendors work closely with the customers and help them throughout the designing process, and provide online and on-site technical support. The support available from

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- LED Modules, Rigid Strip, Strip Light.
- LED Street Lights/Bay Lights & Flood Light Fixtures.

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